GDR's best artistic talent applied to emigrate. Caught completely off guard, Honecker faced a vicious backlash and a barrage of intellectual venom. 'Two months ago, I would never have thought about leaving, but now I am not quite so sure,' one well-known author confessed. Poet Reiner Kunze, actor Manfred Krug and composer Tilo Medek, all highly regarded internationally, were among the first to pack-up. Off too, went scores of creatives and innovators, never to be replaced. Prominent intellectuals previously considered to be in conformity with the system, including Stephan Hermlin and Sarah Kirsch, were left appalled at the Biermann action. In a letter to Honecker, long-time dissident Robert Havemann expressed incomprehension and called for the expatriation to be reversed: 'Accusations and suspicions that he is an enemy of the GDR are simply nonsense,' he wrote.14

Watching with disbelief, even Soviet diplomats viewed the Biermann expulsion as an act of gross clumsiness and began questioning Honecker's logic. 'Instead of worrying about more important things, the SED general secretary occupies himself with thousands of details in the party apparatus, for example, which functionary marries whom and when,' one Russian embassy official angrily observed.15 It was indeed true that even humdrum, squalid business passed the desk of Honecker. For example, he took a close interest when the GDR's Public Prosecutor mulled launching proceedings against actress Marta Rafael, wife of Karl-Eduard von Schnitzler, the chief commentator of GDR TV and host of the virulently anti-Western show Der Schwarze Kanal.16 Rafael was caught shoplifting stockings worth DM16.40 from KaDeWe in West Berlin. Understandably, the incident shook the credibility of her husband, who had shot to fame by demonising the capitalist West by editing together extracts of ARD and ZDF television footage and recording caustic, sharp and malicious commentary over it. For FRG journalists, it was a story sent from heaven. In the following days, they used Rafael's indiscretion as an opportunity to report in detail about the couple's exit privileges, and visits to West Berlin bars and shopping tours on the Kurfürstendamm (a small and privileged circle was permitted to undertake Western travel. This consisted of people like von Schnitzler, functionaries, academics, famous artists and top athletes. This 'travel cadre' was expected to act as upstanding GDR ambassadors, but the danger of defection was great. Over 600 sports personalities did not return).